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【メール原文】

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dear hondo-san,

(not) governing ai. the iran (and the houthi/saudi) war. and (not) containing a rogue russia.

who's in charge of ai?

the science of artificial intelligence is advancing faster than our understanding of how frontier models work and our ability to deploy them as intended. companies are talking more about the risks but remain principally focused on their competition, with no alignment on what risk mitigation should mean for their business activities. the united states government remains hands off, opposing regulation...but leaning into the space given its importance, announcing director of national intelligence jay clayton as the new ai/si czar, supported by a "super intelligence force"—a 120-day task force to provide initial advice and direction.

there's no near-term prospect of governance in an ai environment where, as vince lombardi said "winning isn't everything, it's the only thing." but even though the ai leaders all have two feet on the accelerator (for now), there are three different types of governance that are clearly needed. each is a response to different manifestations of the ai revolution.

1 - ai as superweapon. the more advanced the models, the greater the danger their unregulated deployment will be used as weapons that existentially threaten others. over the next few years. as the united states and china move toward decoupling their ai-related technologies and supply chains, ai development will turn into an arms race more dangerous than the cold war (because it's advancing faster and harder to deter). ai arms control agreements and monitoring will be required between the two countries, with washington and beijing needing to accept that a level of transparency, verification, and cooperation will become essential, especially given the absence of trust.

core areas of development will need to be renounced by both governments—some tactical (like ai restrictions in command and control of nuclear weapons and a lethal autonomous drone ban) and some structural (a ban on ai leading improvement of frontier models and, relatedly, recursive self-improvement because there's no present plausible security measures that could adequately contain them). absent that, incentives of the other country to preemptively destroy the most advanced ai capabilities of the adversary would be high. and since these developments are, for the time being at least, in the private sector, both countries will require oversight of their ai companies to facilitate these agreements.

2 - ai as systemic infrastructure. as artificial intelligence becomes the critical technology underpinning international commerce, national security, and human connection/social function, every government will share a core interest in ensuring its continuous and stable functionality. this comes from a recognition that ai functionality becomes essential for stability—like the global financial markets—but that systemic threats, whether from agent swarms promoting disinformation, cyberweapons, and the like, can

emerge from any quarter, both programmed by actors or even autonomously from ai agents themselves. that requires a global, technocratic monitoring and risk containment mechanism with the capability to identify threats from ai agents as they occur, communicate them, and contain them with an absolute minimum of disruption.

at the narrow end, this is the "finra (financial industry regulatory agency) for ai" model, an independent, industry-led regulatory agency (as suggested by demis hassabis and dario amodei); limited given that it's ultimately constrained/controlled by the corporate actors. another approach is an ai technology stability board, that would broaden actors responsible to include governments (which mustafa suleyman and i have suggested, and now canada pm mark carney is pursuing), important given the national security implications. further along this line would be parallel technocratic ministries of ai that function independently from the governments they serve—essentially more expansive technology/national security versions of today's central bank governors. eventually, unless ai frontier technology is permanently paused, this would evolve into a global governance function.

3 - ai as driver of globalization. as the investment into ai and the impact of the technology expands, who controls the tech, who has access to it, and under what conditions will become the most important determinant of the well-being, development, and even cognition of human beings around the world. worries about the concentration of wealth and power will grow accordingly (with dehumanizing implications for "have nots"), with greater consequence than the explosion of global trade. this is in many ways a more complicated matter than the first two types of governance, since it's addressing more abstract questions about resource distribution where different governments have very different views (for ai as superweapon and systemic infrastructure, the desired outcomes are much clearer and more aligned, it's just a collective action challenge in getting from here to there).

unlike the first two categories, much of this governance response would be different across countries—from right to work agreements, to restrictions on ai companions, and the like—given different values, priorities, and capabilities of governments and nations. still, we can start to see some of the broader international frameworks of governance that could be established: data sovereignty enshrined as an international right like border security; international development funds for ai infrastructure; international (or non-) governmental organizations creating programming and training for open-source models to support sustainable development goals.

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right now, none of these governance capabilities are being developed. at best you'd say a handful of government, business, and adjacent leaders are starting to talk about how they might be built, and looking to broaden support for the concepts accordingly. but they're not just needed, they're needed quickly. for example, if anthropic and openai’s leaders are remotely correct about how close they are to taking frontier model development and training fully out of the hands of humans (privately, they say within one year), some "pacing" (read: a pause) of that development is essential in the coming months.

as such efforts expand, the hope would be that you would build enough momentum to achieve consensus in response to ai-driven crises as they occur. absent that, the danger is that when a crisis happens, it's at best the shoe bomber response where suddenly (and for years) we're all taking our shoes off when we go through security—everyone runs to address that narrow issue and little more. or, worse, the crisis is large enough that it requires a macro fix, but key actors in today's g-zero world respond individually and in a zero-sum way. then we end up speeding toward a more fragmented ai environment despite technologies that demand collective governance...and the next ai crisis becomes a

lot more dangerous.

iran

conflict over the strait of hormuz remains unresolved...but has of late trended toward the united states' position. the us naval blockade has become the principal mechanism of warfare, with iranian oil exports now shut down for nearly two months (with only remaining tankers at sea able to move, but no additional loading). meanwhile exports through the strait are now at nearly pre-war levels.

the united states continues to be unwilling to accept a deal given iranian demands to control the strait—despite continued military threats (though not until after the midterms), the american strategy remains to squeeze the iranians more to force greater flexibility on nuclear enrichment/stockpiling and to end iranian demands on tolling of ships going through the strait...both of which have had some, limited movement over past weeks.

with leverage tilting toward the americans given the success of the blockade, iran's efforts to strike at ships are increasing—with more ships attacked over the last week than during the whole of september. so too the houthis see more leverage from disrupting saudi arabia’s export through the bab al mandab...leading to expanded attacks there as well as major attacks against saudi arabia's principal international airport in riyadh (with 13 civilians killed and over 300 injured), but not against american ships (with the view, correct to date, that will limit the willingness of the americans to get involved).

saudi arabia, facing an expansion of the conflict that feels increasingly existential (from iran, irgc forces in iraq, and houthis in yemen), is now retaliating in what is becoming a second armed regional conflict, attacking territory on yemen's west coast. and given the change in us policy in the region, saudi arabia is looking to broaden their own coalition away from reliance on the united states—with turkey’s drone capabilities, airlift capacity and military advice and technology; pakistan’s air support and ground troops; and defensive support from italy, france and the united kingdom.

only the israelis want to see military attacks restart against iran (in the continued hopes of regime change); across the board the gulf states now believe the regime will not collapse and will retaliate against regional infrastructure, which they remain extremely vulnerable to. and so it's a waiting game—likely for a matter of months—while the us economic blockade and sanctions increase political pressure; the iranians engage in further strikes; and the united states (after the midterms) considers more strikes in return. with all of that constrained by an unwillingness to risk uncontained escalation.

the eventual "deal" on the disposition of the strait will need to be negotiated between the iranians and the gulf states. while the americans negotiate on the nuclear program and the status of iran's uranium enrichment program and highly enriched uranium stockpiles—with an understanding/commitment that the americans won't finalize any deal until iran comes to terms with the gulf states.

russia

a sudden plague scare from russia last week, and we still know very little about it. a 28-year-old bio-laboratory researcher died with an unknown infection. the russian government says it wasn't related to her lab work and refuses to say what she died of. there's been little news on it domestically, with competing reporting on what she has (plague or an unknown virus) and where she might have gotten sick (in her hometown, on the mongolian border, in thailand...). meanwhile, the russian government immediately quarantined hundreds of people.

it raises the broader issue of governance in russia. unlike other major countries in the world, russia is governed by a 74-year-old president with poor information, increasingly incompetent loyalists around him, no meaningful checks and balances on his executive authority, no succession mechanism, and at active war with the west. that would be concerning in the best of domestic circumstances...and right now developments in the war are trending to exacerbate those concerns: the russian economy is struggling, the population is increasingly unhappy, and putin's willingness to repress exceeds moscow's post-stalin soviet-era. unlike other rogue states (say north korea) russia's status quo looks increasingly challenging to maintain.

the willingness of us president trump to directly engage the kremlin in this environment emboldens putin. after all, president putin has only escalated his fighting despite trump's promise and efforts to end the war (and ukrainian president zelenskyy's willingness to accept a ceasefire without preconditions); now he's on the receiving end of a deal to export diesel fuel to the americans and white house-supported business entreaties to buy the damaged assets of the nordstream 2 pipeline, while president trump this weekend says zelenskyy is unfit to govern ukraine (putin agrees), with the white house threatening to suspend intelligence and weapon sales.

and so, we now see a russia with lots of nukes, that they have stepped up threats to use—if kaliningrad is surrounded, if the europeans expand troops on the border, etc. and a russia with some of the world's most significant bioweapon capabilities, while resources are overwhelmingly going into the war economy.

crazier things are likely to happen in that environment. after all, the (wagner group leader) prighozin uprising in the early days of the war would have been previously unheard of in a country marshalling that kind of power. it turned out putin could easily suppress it (and have him assassinated a couple months later). but that was when putin (and russia) was in a stronger domestic position. how about a year later? how about five? as putin takes more risks and gets himself into more trouble.

at some point, something dangerous (either to putin domestically, or internationally) happens and russia proves unable to cover it up or contain it. it's worth watching this bioscare accordingly—not because we're about to face a new pandemic, but to learn as much as possible about the state of putin's crisis management capabilities.

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i'm back in new york this week...drop a note if you like :)

yours truly,

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